



The Timer Doesn't Travel

A Failed Off-Campus Replication of a Booked-but-Empty-Room Release Agent

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Background

A campus release agent that reclaims booked-but-empty study rooms after a grace window lifted room utilisation without a matching rise in evictions. Whether the same design does anything for meeting rooms booked by the public, rather than students on a class schedule, has not been tested.

Aims

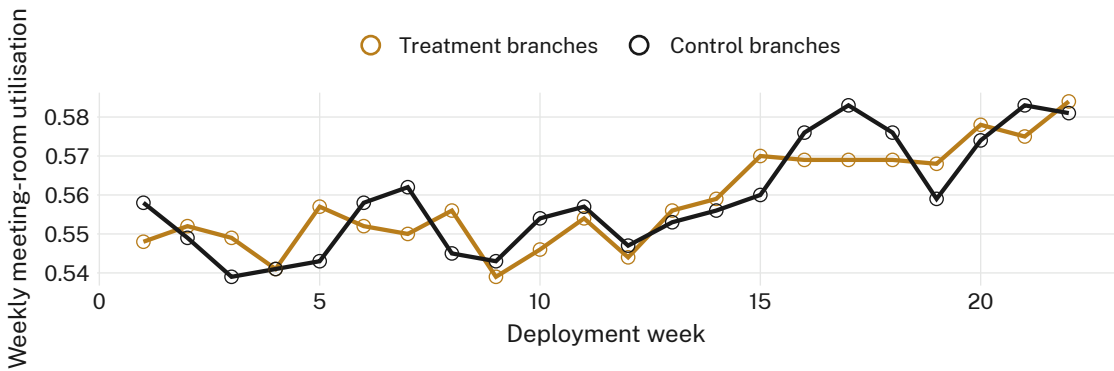
- Redeploy the campus release agent's grace-window design unmodified at public library branches
- Compare weekly meeting-room utilisation between treatment and matched control branches
- Audit near-miss evictions under the same grace window as the original campus trial

Methods

- 3 treatment branches · 3 matched control branches · regional public library system
- 12-minute grace window, held constant from the campus parameter · check-in via the existing self-service kiosk tap
- 22-week deployment · thresholds pre-registered, none adjusted post hoc

Results

Weekly utilisation at treatment branches tracked matched controls throughout the deployment window, with no divergence resembling the original campus effect. Near-miss eviction incidence held close to the rate reported on campus.



Treatment-branch utilisation closed the 22-week trial (15 September 2025–16 February 2026) at 58.4%, against 58.1% at matched control branches — a gap the original campus deployment had already opened to several points by the same point in its own trial.

Discussion & conclusions

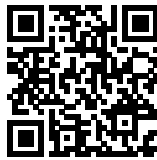
The campus effect may depend on class-block scheduling pressure that a public-library patron base doesn't share evenly across a week. Near-miss risk appears to travel with the grace window regardless of setting, even where the utilisation benefit does not. Next: test whether a patron-visible countdown display, absent from this deployment, is what the campus effect actually required.

References

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We thank the participating branches' staff. Booking-level occupancy only; no patron identity retained.

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“The same timer, a different building — and no lift in sight.”

Weekly utilisation held within a point of the control branches for all 22 weeks of the trial.